

for your device. In the long run, over multiple purchases, you will end up saving money.

BROWSER EXTENSIONS

There are a number of browser extensions that make your shopping experience better. One of these made for Indian extensions is called Buy-Hatke. It automatically retrieves any applicable coupons, and also shows a price history of the product. There are a number of extensions that let you see the price histories of products, and this is important to make sure that you are getting the best deal possible, and are not falling for fake discounts. If you are unwilling to use extensions,



The Buy Hatke plugin

pricehistory.in is a good alternative that tracks product prices on Indian e-commerce sites.

InvisibleHand is a US-based plugin, but the deals available are so great, that at times it might actually be cheaper to ship to India as against buying the product locally. However, bear in mind that the warranty may not be applicable in India for such purchases. While many browser extensions can be configured to send you alerts on your browser in case there is a price drop for certain products, you can configure IFTTT to send you alerts on your smartphone, so you can swoop in and make a purchase. The simplest way to do this is to install Telegram. Look for the RSS to telegram applet by scorpmanuz. Then configure IFTTT to send you an update on Telegram every time there is a particular update to an RSS feed. To do this, you need to link IFTTT to your Telegram account, then authorise IFTTT on Telegram. Another option to get a good price drop is to join channels such as IndiaDeals on Telegram at <https://t.me/>

dealsindia. Digit readers have made their own tools for helping with online shopping. Cute.bandar has put up a site for criteria-based searches, where you can narrow down on products based on the desired features, as well as advanced search capabilities. The tool can be accessed at <https://dgit.in/flnprcs>. Sudhir Mangla has made a chrome extension for comparing prices of the same product across e-commerce sites such as Flipkart, Amazon and Snapdeal. The extension can be downloaded at <https://dgit.in/desideals>.

CHINESE SITES

There are some shady sites with non-existent support, no return policy, ridiculously inconsistent images, all together giving the impression that you should never put your credit card info in them. However, if you do decide to take the risk, the payoffs can be pretty great sometimes. These kinds of purchases make sense for really cheap stuff. In some cases, these are the only sites where certain products are available. Like, who does not want a telescoping magnetic retrieval tool? Of course, make sure to look for https and the lock sign. Shein is good for apparel, Wish for tools, desk toys, gadgets and trinkets, Aliexpress for everything from imitation jewelry, to replicas to polyhedral dice. Many of these sites have steep discounts for bulk orders. In this case, it is a good idea to have a group of people to distribute the products to, once they arrive. Bear in mind that the shipping cycles can be incredibly long, and there might not be tracking details available.

SITE FEATURES

Apart from hunting for coupons, discount codes and offers, there are also some nifty tricks you can do with the sites. One of them is to make a wish list, and then allow the sites to notify you when there are discounts for the selected products. Look for alternative product names, at times the same product may be listed at different price points with slightly different names. If there are no sales going on, keep the items in a shopping list, but do not make the purchase. Let it simmer for a few days or a week. Typically,

sites will send you an alert with a discount prompting you to finalise the sale. Make it a habit to check today's deals on Amazon. The Amazon Prime membership is also great, and you can try it for free. However, do not be trapped by the service, and stop it once you are done with a shopping. It is a good idea to go on a spree for the last three months of the year, then end the subscription. On Flipkart, make sure to check the seller rating as well, apart from the product rating.

BEYOND REVIEWS

User reviews are great, but the seller can easily get fake reviews and they do not always tell the whole story. By and large, it is not a good idea to depend on user reviews alone before making a purchase. However, to get the most out of the user reviews, it is a good idea to install an extension such as Fakespot, which will flag the bogus reviews. For products that are particularly susceptible to be faked, such as earphones, watches and board games, it is a good idea to watch unboxing videos and look at high resolution images from the manufacturer's site. There are also particular sites that detail the differences between real and fake products. Watching videos of a product in use will anyway give you a better idea of the pros and cons.

Next, for certain categories of products, there are specialised sites and forums that go into the details of the product. For example, JonnyGURU is dedicated to PSUs, TypeHype or geekhack deal with mechanical keyboards and TFTcentral for displays. Typically these forums will have a tier list, that will let you pick the best products available. Also bear in mind, that even though some options might be expensive, there is sense in the logic of "can't afford to buy cheap", when it comes to certain products. The idea is to invest in long lasting things, where you only need to invest once. Before finalising on a particular product, it is also a good idea to read comparative reviews where they are available. User reviews on e-commerce sites will rarely have information on the comparative strengths and weaknesses of the products. **[4]**